

One transition point hypothesis

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Abstract: Transition points, the beginnings and ends of events, are linguistically significant, as they figure prominently in predicate classification. This work studies how transition points are represented in language and proposes the *One Transition Point Hypothesis* (OTPH), which states that each event can linguistically encode at most one transition point, thereby ruling out the cooccurrence of both transition points in the same structure. I derive this hypothesis by building on Travis's (1991, 2002, 2005, 2010) proposal of an inner Asp head, which I argue is responsible for licensing both transition points. This analysis carries significant implications for predicate classification as well as for θ -role assignment.

Keywords: *final points, initial points, inner aspect, predicate classes, θ -roles*

1 Introduction

Transition points are the boundaries of events, their beginnings (*initial points*) and ends (*final points*), and have played a crucial role in predicate classification (see, e.g., van Voorst 1988; Smith 1991/1997; Bar-el 2005). Smith (1991/1997), for example, argues that states lack transition points, activities have only an initial point, and accomplishments and achievements have both; in achievements, however, the two points coincide. Notably, theories that recognize both initial and final points typically treat them as freely cooccurring (van Voorst 1988; Smith 1991/1997; Ritter and Rosen 1998, 2000; MacDonald 2008; Ramchand 2008). In contrast, drawing on evidence from Mandarin and English, I propose the *One Transition Point Hypothesis* (OTPH), stated in (1).

(1) *One Transition Point Hypothesis* (OTPH)

An event may have at most one transition point linguistically represented.

This hypothesis constrains the linguistic representation of event boundaries: an event's initial and final points can never cooccur in the same structure. Although English

accomplishments may appear to pass tests for both transition points, I will argue that many of them are ambiguous, with one reading projecting only an initial point and the other projecting only a final point. Mandarin provides particularly compelling evidence, as it formally distinguishes between the two: bare accomplishments encode only initial points, while derived accomplishments with the completive marker *-wan* encode only final points.

I deduce the OTPH by adopting Travis's (1991, 2002, 2005, 2010) proposal of an Asp head within vP (inner Asp), which can host only one syntactic instantiation of a transition point, thereby ruling out the cooccurrence of both initial and final points in the syntax. Unlike Travis (2010), who treats final points as the [+telic] feature on Asp, I argue that the relation between final points and Asp is more indirect. Specifically, Asp does not inherently encode either initial or final points; rather, it involves in deriving both. In other words, the presence of Asp is necessary but insufficient for the syntactic representation of transition points.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces two tests for transition points and presents initial evidence from Mandarin for the OTPH. Section 3 shows that final points correspond to resultativity rather than telicity. Section 4 discusses potential counterexamples from English accomplishments. Section 5 examines how the OTPH is reflected in argument structure, suggesting a link between transition points and θ -role assignment. Section 6 derives the OTPH from Travis's inner Asp head and analyzes the data discussed in the preceding sections. Section 7 concludes.

2 Motivating the OTPH

In this section, I draw on Mandarin data and apply two tests for transition points to show that activities in this language encode only initial points, while their accomplishment counterparts with the completive marker *-wan* encode only final points. This supports the OTPH by demonstrating the impossibility of representing both transition points in the same structure.

The first test involves *before*-clauses. The predicate *zuo zuoye* 'do (one's) homework' in (2a) is an activity. When embedded under a *before*-clause, it yields only the initial point reading, locating the time prior to the onset of the homework-doing event. In contrast, the predicate in (2b) differs minimally by including the completive marker *-wan*, which shifts the activity into an accomplishment. Here, the *before*-clause only allows the final point reading, targeting the time preceding the event's completion. Crucially, it does not have the initial point reading 'before I started to do the homework (which I finished later)'. This suggests that the completive marker not only introduces a final point but also suppresses the initial point otherwise available, fitting with the OTPH.

- | | | |
|--------|--|-----------------------------------|
| (2) a. | zai wo zuo zuoye zhiqian, ...
at I do homework before
'before I started to do the homework, ...' | <i>initial point reading only</i> |
| b. | zai wo zuo- wan zuoye zhiqian, ...
at I do-CMPL homework before
'before I finished the homework, ...' | <i>final point reading only</i> |

The adverb ‘almost’ provides another test for transition points and has been widely discussed in the literature (see, e.g., Morgan 1969; McCawley 1971; Dowty 1979:58–59, 241–244; Pustejovsky 1991; Rapp and von Stechow 1999; Bar-el 2005:70–74; MacDonald 2008:64–68). Its behavior parallels that of *before*-clauses. When the predicate is an activity, as in (3a), ‘almost’ targets the event’s initial point, yielding a *counterfactual* reading: the implication is that I did not even start the homework. When the completive marker *-wan* is added, as in (3b), ‘almost’ instead targets the event’s final point, producing an *incompletive* reading: I started the homework but did not finish it. Crucially, (3b) does not have the interpretation that I never started the homework. If the initial point were still present, the counterfactual reading would also be available, contrary to fact. This pattern further demonstrates that an event’s two transition points cannot cooccur, providing additional support for the OTPH.

- (3) a. wo chadian zuo-le zuoye.
 I almost do-PFV homework
 ✓ ‘I almost started to do the homework.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✗ ‘I almost finished doing the homework.’ *incompletive reading*
- b. wo chadian zuo-**wan**-le zuoye.
 I almost do- CMPL-PFV homework
 ✗ ‘I almost started to do the homework.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✓ ‘I almost finished doing the homework.’ *incompletive reading*

3 Final points correspond to resultativity

The notions most closely associated with final points include *telicity* (Garey 1957), (*set*) *terminal point* (Vendler 1957; Krifka 1989), *boundedness* (Declerck 1979; Kiparsky 1998), and *culmination* (Parsons 1990). For simplicity, I refer to these collectively as *telicity*. Representing an event’s final point in terms of telicity follows a long tradition in which telicity is defined as the natural endpoint of an event (McCawley 1968; Declerck 1979; Dowty 1979; Parsons 1990; Van Valin 1990; Pustejovsky 1991, 1995; Depraetere 1995; van Hout 1996; Van Valin and LaPolla 1997; Higginbotham 2000; Kratzer 2004, among many others). However, applying the two transition point tests introduced in the previous section to Mandarin bare accomplishments suggests that telicity does not entail the presence of a final point. I argue instead that it is *resultativity* that linguistically represents final points.

In addition to accomplishments marked with *-wan*, Mandarin also features bare accomplishments, where telicity is determined by the quantificational properties of the objects. As shown in (4), the verb *chi* ‘eat’ combined with a quantized object such as ‘that bag of chips’ is telic, as indicated by compatibility with the adverbial ‘in ten minutes,’ and thus forms a canonical bare accomplishment.

- (4) wo zai shi fenzhong nei chi-le na bao shupian.
 I at ten minutes in eat-PFV that bag chips
 ‘I ate that bag of chips in ten minutes.’

Applying the *before*-clause test and the ‘almost’ test to the predicate ‘eat that bag of chips’ shows that Mandarin bare accomplishments pattern with activities: they project an initial point but lack a final point. In (5), the *before*-clause yields only the initial point reading, while in (6), ‘almost’ produces only the counterfactual reading. This indicates that although Mandarin bare accomplishments may be interpreted as telic, they consistently lack final points. It follows that telicity does not entail final points.

- (5) zai wo chi na bao shupian zhiqian, ... *initial point reading only*
 at I eat that bag chips before
 ‘before I started to eat that bag of chips, ...’

- (6) wo chadian chi-le na bao shupian.
 I almost eat-PFV that bag chips
 ✓ ‘I almost started to eat that bag of chips.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✗ ‘I almost finished eating that bag of chips.’ *incompletive reading*

So, which linguistic property correlates with final points? I propose that the relevant notion is *resultativity*. Both the completive marker *-wan* and resultative morphemes manifest this property. If resultatives, like *-wan*, introduce final points, we should expect the patterns observed in (2–3) to be replicated when a resultative is added. This expectation is borne out. The predicate ‘comfort me’ in (7a) is an activity, and the associated *before*-clause allows only the initial point reading. However, when the semantically bleached resultative ‘arrive’ is added, the derived accomplishment loses its initial point and acquires a final point, leaving the final point reading as the only possible interpretation of the *before*-clause.

- (7) a. zai ta anwei wo zhiqian, ... *initial point reading only*
 at he comfort me before
 ‘before he started to comfort me, ...’
 b. zai ta anwei-**dao** wo zhiqian, ... *final point reading only*
 at he comfort-**arrive** me before
 ‘before he made me feel comforted, ...’

The adverb ‘almost’ illustrates a similar pattern: with the activity ‘comfort me,’ it elicits a counterfactual reading (see (8a)), but with the resultative form ‘comfort-arrive me,’ it induces an incompletive reading (see (8b)). Therefore, resultatives pattern with the completive marker *-wan* in introducing a final point.

- (8) a. ta chadian anwei-le wo.
 he almost comfort-PFV me
 ✓ ‘He almost started to comfort me.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✗ ‘He almost made me feel comforted.’ *incompletive reading*

- b. ta chadian anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 he almost comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ✗ ‘He almost started to comfort me.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✓ ‘He almost made me feel comforted.’ *incompletive reading*

4 Explaining potential counterexamples

At first glance, English accomplishments seem to contradict the OTPH. Consider the predicate *comfort me*. In (9), the *before*-clause allows both an initial point and a final point reading, while in (10), the adverb *almost* yields both a counterfactual and an incompletive reading, suggesting that both initial and final points are linguistically represented by the same accomplishment predicate.

- (9) before he comforted me, ...
 ✓ before he started to comfort me, ... *initial point reading*
 ✓ before he made me feel comforted, ... *final point reading*
- (10) He almost comforted me.
 ✓ He didn’t even start to comfort me. *counterfactual reading*
 ✓ He failed to make me feel comforted. *incompletive reading*

However, the data in (9–10) do not necessarily constitute a counterexample to the OTPH. If *comfort me* is ambiguous, patterning either with the activity ‘comfort’ or with the accomplishment ‘comfort-arrive’ in Mandarin, the apparent coexistence of both transition points can be reanalyzed. Specifically, the initial point reading of the *before*-clause and the counterfactual reading of *almost* would stem from the activity use of *comfort me*, while the final point reading of the *before*-clause and the incompletive reading of *almost* would stem from its accomplishment use. On this analysis, the OTPH is respected.

Additional evidence supports this view. In Mandarin, the activity ‘comfort me’ and the accomplishment ‘comfort-arrive me’ differ in their selectional restrictions: the activity requires a volitional subject (see (11)), while the accomplishment allows both volitional and non-volitional subjects (see (12)).

- (11) a. ta anwei-le wo.
 he comfort-PFV me
 ‘He comforted me.’
 b. *na shou ge anwei-le wo.
 that CL song comfort-PFV me
- (12) a. ta anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 he comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ‘He made me comforted.’

- b. na shou ge anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 that CL song comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ‘That song made me feel comforted.’

(13) shows that a *before*-clause with the predicate ‘comfort-arrive me’ and a non-volitional subject yields only a final point reading, while (14) shows that ‘almost’ with the same predicate and subject produces only an incompleted reading.

- (13) zai na shou ge anwei-**dao** wo zhiqian, ... *final point reading only*
 at that CL song comfort-**arrive** me before
 ‘before that song made me feel comforted, ...’
- (14) na shou ge chadian anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 that CL song almost comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ✗ ‘That song almost started to comfort me.’ *counterfactual reading*
 ✓ ‘That song almost made me feel comforted.’ *incompleted reading*

If the English predicate *comfort me* is indeed ambiguous, we would expect this distinction between its two uses to emerge with non-volitional subjects. Specifically, we predict that with a non-volitional subject, this predicate should allow only a final point reading in a *before*-clause and only an incompleted reading with ‘almost.’ This prediction is borne out, as illustrated in (15) and (16).

- (15) before that song comforted me, ...
 ✗ before that song started to comfort me, ...
 ✓ before that song made me feel comforted, ...
- (16) That song almost comforted me.
 ✗ That song didn’t even start to comfort me.
 ✓ That song failed to make me feel comforted.

If *comfort me* were unambiguous, we would not expect its behavior to vary with the subject’s volitionality. I therefore conclude that English accomplishments do not contradict the OTPH: they are ambiguous between an activity use and an accomplishment use, each of which independently conforms to the hypothesis. While the two uses are overtly distinguished in Mandarin, the distinction in English is less transparent, but still detectable.

5 Reflection in argument structure

Final points play an important role in θ -role assignment and the classification of internal arguments. They have been argued to license internal arguments bearing the *Measure* or *Incremental Theme* θ -role (e.g., Tenny 1987; Dowty 1991; Borer 1994, 2005). Evidence for this connection comes from case assignment: in Finnish, for example, internal arguments in

predicates with a final point take accusative case, while those in predicates without a final point take partitive case (e.g., de Hoop 1992; Arad 1998; Borer 2005; Travis 2010).

Initial points have also been linked, though less extensively, to the definition and classification of external arguments. Researchers such as van Voorst (1988), Borer (1994), Ritter and Rosen (1998, 2000), MacDonald (2008), and Ramchand (2008) propose that external arguments, or at least a subset of them, can be characterized as initiators of an event. In this sense, initial points are essential for licensing this class of external arguments. As a result, certain external arguments are expected to inherit from initial points the restriction against cooccurring with final points, as required by the OTPH. I will show that this expectation is borne out, providing further evidence for the OTPH.

In what follows, I present two constructions that illustrate the existence of external arguments incompatible with final points. Given the correlation between final points and resultativity argued for in section 3, I refer to this property as *anti-resultativity*. The external argument of Mandarin psych-verbs such as ‘comfort’ provides the first example of such an external argument. Recall that the bare form of this verb imposes a volitionality restriction on its subject, as illustrated in (11) (repeated below).

- (11) a. ta anwei-le wo.
 he comfort-PFV me
 ‘He comforted me.’
 b. *na shou ge anwei-le wo.
 that CL song comfort-PFV me

However, this restriction is relaxed if the resultative ‘arrive’ is added to the verb (see (12), repeated below). This indicates that the external argument selected by the activity ‘comfort,’ which is necessarily volitional, shifts to a different class of external argument, one that is optionally volitional, once a final point is introduced through the resultative ‘arrive.’ In other words, the external argument of the activity ‘comfort’ is incompatible with final points and is thus anti-resultative.

- (12) a. ta anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 he comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ‘He made me comforted.’
 b. na shou ge anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 that CL song comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 ‘That song made me feel comforted.’

Another case of anti-resultative external arguments is found with the sole arguments of unergatives. A well-known test for distinguishing unaccusatives from unergatives in Mandarin is *subject inversion*: unaccusatives allow their sole arguments to remain *in situ* or move to a preverbal position (17), while unergatives require their sole arguments to appear in the preverbal position (18) (see, e.g., Huang 1990).

- (17) a. xuduo ren lai-le. *unaccusative, ✓ preverbal subject*
 many people come-PFV
 ‘Many people came.’
 b. lai-le xuduo ren. *unaccusative, ✓ postverbal subject*
 come-PFV many people
 ‘Many people came.’
- (18) a. xuduo ren ku-le. *unergative, ✓ preverbal subject*
 many people cry-PFV
 ‘Many people cried.’
 b. *ku-le xuduo ren. *unergative, ✗ postverbal subject*
 cry-PFV many people

Interestingly, when the resultative *yun* ‘faint’ is added, the unergative *ku* ‘cry’ behaves like an unaccusative, allowing the subject to occur either preverbal (19a) or postverbal (19b). In other words, the sole arguments of unergatives shift from external to internal when a final point is introduced, thereby qualifying as anti-resultative.

- (19) a. xuduo ren ku-**yun**-le. *✓ preverbal subject*
 many people cry-**faint**-PFV
 ‘Many people cried and fainted.’
 b. ku-**yun**-le xuduo ren. *✓ postverbal subject*
 cry-**faint**-PFV many people
 ‘Many people cried and fainted.’

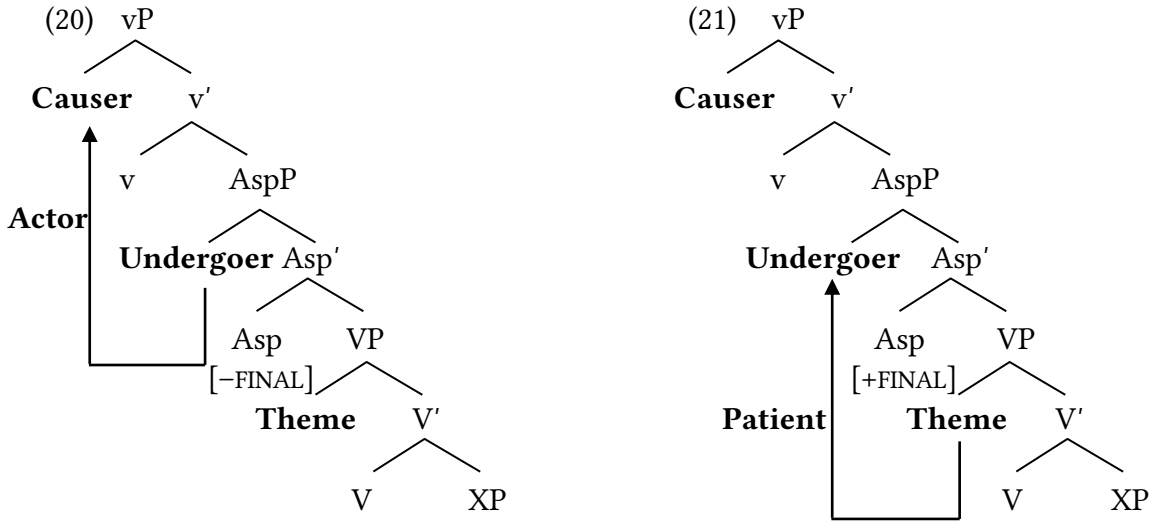
The two constructions discussed so far (Mandarin psych-verbs and unergatives) thus demonstrate the existence of anti-resultative external arguments. These are arguments that cannot cooccur with a final point and that shift to a class of arguments that behave differently with respect to some grammatical phenomenon whenever a linguistic final point is introduced. The existence of this class of external arguments is exactly what the OTPH predicts, providing further confirmation of the hypothesis.

6 Syntactic representation of transition points

Before turning to the analysis, it is useful to summarize the generalizations about transition points established so far. First, both initial and final points are linguistically represented. Second, their representation is constrained by the OTPH, which prohibits the cooccurrence of initial and final points. Third, transition points play a role in θ -role assignment: the θ -role associated with initial points is anti-resultative and thus incompatible with final points.

I propose that a transitive predicate may take the structure in (20) or (21). (20) represents activities and bare accomplishments, while (21) represents accomplishments marked with *-wan* and resultative constructions (potentially also achievements). Following Travis (1991, 2002, 2005, 2010), I assume an inner Asp head situated between vP and VP. This inner Asp has two flavors, depending on the value of the [FINAL] feature. When the feature is negative,

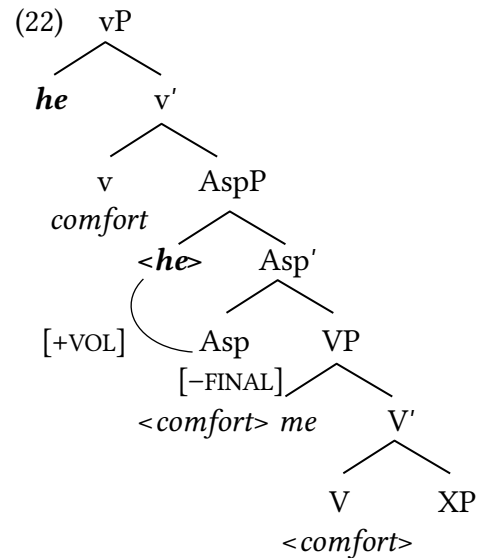
Asp encodes an initial point (20); when positive, it encodes a final point (21). Crucially, the [FINAL] feature cannot simultaneously take both values, which rules out the cooccurrence of initial and final points and derives the OTPH.



Having derived the first two generalizations, I now turn to the third, which concerns θ -role assignment. I propose that v, Asp, and V assign the Causer, Undergoer, and Theme θ -roles to the arguments in their respective specifiers. The movement of these arguments is determined by the value of the [FINAL] feature on Asp. When [FINAL] is negative, as in (20), the Undergoer argument in Spec, AspP obligatorily raises to Spec, vP. When [FINAL] is positive, as in (21), Asp attracts the Theme from Spec, VP to its specifier. Through such movement, θ -roles can combine to form composite θ -roles (for discussion on movement into θ -positions see, e.g., Bošković 1994; Lasnik 1995; Hornstein 1999; Ramchand 2008). Specifically, Causer + Undergoer yields the Actor θ -role, while Undergoer + Theme yields the Patient θ -role. Since Actors are licensed only when Asp has a [-FINAL] feature, they cannot cooccur with a final point, making them anti-resultative, as shown in section 5.

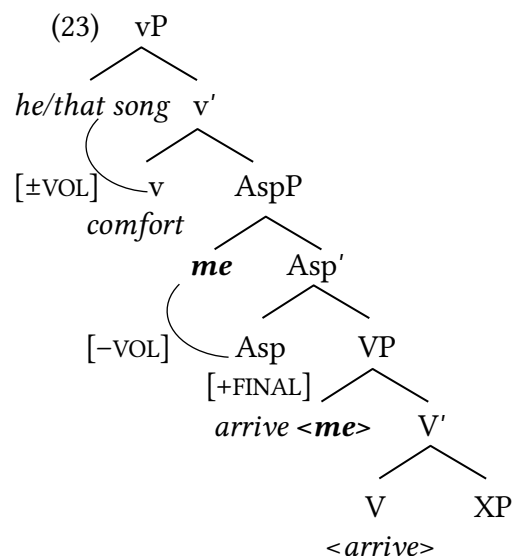
Let us apply the analysis to (11) and (12), repeated below. When the psych-verb *anwei* ‘comfort’ forms an atelic predicate, as in (11a), the structure includes a [-FINAL] Asp, which triggers the movement of the external argument ‘he’ from Spec, AspP to Spec, vP (see (22)). The external argument thus receives the composite θ -role Actor. The internal argument ‘me’ remains in its base-generated position, Spec, VP, and is assigned the Theme θ -role. Assuming that the [-FINAL] Asp associated with ‘comfort’ requires a volitional specifier, the contrast between (11a) and (11b) follows naturally.

- (11) a. ta anwei-le wo.
 he comfort-PFV me
 'He comforted me.'
 b. *na shou ge
 that CL song
 anwei-le wo.
 comfort-PFV me

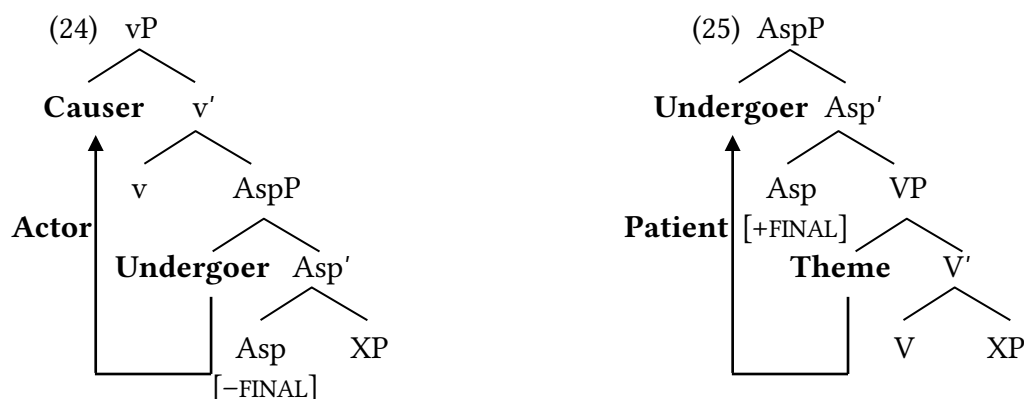


When the resultative *dao* 'arrive' is attached to the verb *anwei* 'comfort,' as in (12), I argue that a [+FINAL] Asp is projected, which hosts the resultative (see (23)). In this configuration, 'comfort' modifies only v, while 'arrive' modifies both V and Asp. The internal argument 'me' raises from Spec, VP to Spec, AspP, where it receives the composite θ -role Patient. The external argument 'he' is base-generated in Spec, vP and interpreted as a Causer. Assuming that v does not require its subject to be volitional, this argument may be either volitional or non-volitional. Since the internal argument cannot be interpreted as volitional in (12), I assume that the [+FINAL] Asp associated with the resultative 'arrive' requires its specifier to be non-volitional.

- (12) a. ta anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 he comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 'He made me comforted.'
 b. na shou ge
 that CL song
 anwei-**dao**-le wo.
 comfort-**arrive**-PFV me
 'That song made me feel comforted.'



To complete the picture, I suggest that intransitives differ from transitives in lacking either the VP in (20) (see (24)) or the vP in (21) (see (25)). (24) represents unergatives, while (25) represents unaccusatives. A fuller exploration of this distinction is left for future work.



7 Conclusion

I have argued that both the initial and final points of events in the real world are represented in language. Crucially, however, this representation is constrained by the *One Transition Point Hypothesis* (OTPH):

(1) *One Transition Point Hypothesis* (OTPH)

An event may have at most one transition point linguistically represented.

This hypothesis is supported by two transition point tests and by the existence of anti-resultative external arguments, which reflect the OTPH in argument structure.

I deduced the OTPH from an Asp head situated between vP and VP, which is responsible for licensing both initial and final points. An initial point arises when Asp is specified as [-FINAL], triggering movement of an argument from Spec, AspP to Spec, vP. A final point arises when Asp is specified as [+FINAL], attracting an argument from Spec, VP to Spec, AspP. Since the [FINAL] feature cannot be simultaneously positive and negative, the OTPH follows naturally.

The study of transition points has several implications. First, it clarifies our understanding of predicate classes. It showed that final points correspond to resultativity rather than telicity. In fact, activities (atelic) and bare accomplishments (telic) behave alike under transition point tests: they project only initial points. This suggests that resultativity must play a role in predicate classification. Moreover, tests for accomplishments must be reevaluated, since many turn out to be ambiguous between different classes. Extra caution is required in analyzing phenomena involving accomplishments.

Second, this study provides a method for aspectually classifying external arguments. While various aspectual notions, most prominently telicity, have been used to classify internal arguments, efforts to extend this to external arguments have met with limited success

(Levin and Rappaport Hovav 2005: 111). I have proposed two well-defined properties that can distinguish Causers and Actors: initial points and anti-resultativity. Further exploration of these properties promises to deepen our understanding of θ -role assignment more generally.

Abbreviations

CL = classifier, CMPL = completive, PFV = perfective.

Acknowledgements

This work has greatly benefited from comments by Željko Bošković, Adrian Stegovec, and Vicki Carstens. I am grateful to Zixi Liu, Robin Jenkins, Penelope Daniel, Beccy Lewis, and Walter Shaw for their language judgements. I also thank the audiences of The Workshop on Theoretical East Asian Linguistics (TEAL) 14 and Generative Linguistics in the Old World (GLOW) 47 for their valuable feedback.

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